formed the Jaish-ul-Muslimeen (JuM) under the leadership of Syed Akbar Agha.[22] The high-profile split within the Taliban was followed by kidnapping of three UN personnel by the JuM, and Agha's subsequent arrest and torture in, and by, Pakistan. A year later, in 2013, Agha told this author about his warmth for India as a friendly neighbouring country, unlike Pakistan, for which he had nurtured a special grouse.[23]

India also found an unexpected ally in Mullah Abdal Salam Rocketi, another senior Taliban commander from south Afghanistan, who had been close to Mullah Omar, but began participating in mainstream Afghan politics after the Taliban's rout. According to R&AW officials, Rocketi was paid by private contractors employing Indian (and other) citizens to gather real-time intelligence and sending armed men to save kidnapped Indian (and other) workers.[24] Tactical collaboration with active or ex-Taliban figures was relatively easy for India. But opening a political channel with those Taliban factions that operated from Pakistan's territory and were dependent on Pakistan's support was operationally difficult. For example, Qari Muhammad Yusuf Ahmedi, the Taliban spokesman who called international press agencies informing about the Taliban's demands in Kutty and Suryanarayana's case, actively shuttled between Pakistan and Afghanistan. Indian parliamentarians, who used the term 'Taliban' as a monolith, were not aware of these operational, but critical, distinctions. Eleven Indians and twenty-nine Afghans were killed during the construction of the Zaranj-Delaram highway (one life lost for every 1.5 km) whereas more Indians were kidnapped and/or killed over the years.[25]

These kidnappings did not force a policy rethink, but surely initiated a policy learning process whereby India started distilling different Afghan Taliban factions based on their operational linkages, organisational interests, political aims and ideologies (if any), and strategic dependencies. Non-engagement on ideological or human rights lines (such as the Afghan Taliban was a misogynistic Islamist outfit inherently hostile to India) ceased to be the operational dictum, even though it dominated popular discourse. Memories of the IC-814 hijacking and Bamiyan Buddha destruction, which were fresh among policymakers and analysts alike, did not stop Indian spies and diplomats from engaging with various Taliban factions. According to Benoy Khare, Assistant Director at the Joint